



Think College National Coordinating Center: *A National Perspective*

*Susanna Miller-Raines, Rebecca Lazo, Russell Thelin,
and Stephanie Smith Lee*

Think College

Institute for Community Inclusion
University of Massachusetts Boston

SEPSEA Meeting
April 18-19, 2018

 **ThinkCollege**
NATIONAL COORDINATING CENTER

Good Morning and Welcome!



The TPSID National Coordinating Center at Think College is a project of the
Institute for Community Inclusion at UMass Boston.
The Center is funded by the Office of Postsecondary Education Grant #P407B100002.



Inclusive Postsecondary Education: *A National Perspective*

What's new with Think College?

What's going on nationally with vocational rehabilitation?

What's new on Accreditation Standards?

What's new with Higher Education Act Reauthorization?



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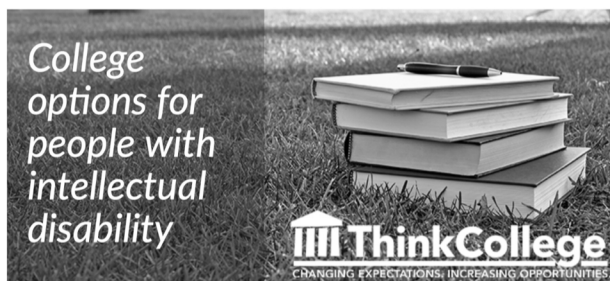
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Think College National Coordinating Center

Federally funded since 2010 to provide coordination, training, and technical assistance to any college or university who wants to establish or improve postsecondary education opportunities to students with intellectual disability on their campus.

www.thinkcollege.net



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Think College Publications

SNAPSHOT
HIGHER EDUCATION ACCESS FOR STUDENTS WITH INTELLECTUAL DISABILITY IN THE UNITED STATES
SEPTEMBER 14, 2017

270 HIGHER EDUCATION PROGRAMS
in 47 STATES

31 STATES HAVE RECEIVED TPSID GRANTS (2010-2020)

63 CTPs in 25 states
have policy or legislation on inclusive higher education

15 STATES
have state or regional coordination

22 STATES
have state or regional coordination

Higher education options for students with intellectual disability (ID) have grown due to changes in federal funding, access to Title IV aid, as well as state legislation and leadership. The Higher Education Opportunity Act (HEOA, 2008) created model demonstration programs, called Transition and Postsecondary Programs for Students with Intellectual Disabilities (TPSID). Five-year grants were awarded to institutions of higher education for 2010-2015 and 2015-2020 to develop TPSID programs. The HEOA also created a new designation – Comprehensive Transition and Postsecondary (CTP) program – that allows approved IHEs to offer specific kinds of federal student aid to qualified students with ID. Additionally, growing numbers of states are conducting strategic planning via statewide consortiums and passing legislation to support development and implementation of higher education options. This Think College SNAPSHOT provides a summary of these markers of systemic change supporting higher education access for students with ID in the United States.

SUGGESTED CITATION:
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Think College FAST FACTS
Access to the Disability Supports Office by Students with Intellectual Disability in TPSID Programs
By Clare Papp, Fred A. Smith, & Meg Grigal
INTRODUCTION

In the United States, Section 504 of the Rehabilitation Act and the Americans with Disabilities Act require institutions of higher education (IHEs) to provide students with disabilities reasonable accommodations that enable equal access to participation in postsecondary education programs (U.S. Department of Education (DOE), 2015). Many colleges and universities have a disability support office (DSO), and students must describe and provide documentation of their disabilities to the DSO to access accommodations (DOE, 2015).

Typically, only about 33% of postsecondary education students with disabilities were found to self-identify their disability, and only 24% receive accommodations (Henneman & Mahow, 2015). Students with intellectual disability are eligible to access accommodations for postsecondary education programs and classes (Henneman, Voss, & Kahn, 2015). However, many programs have been established but provide supports for students with intellectual disability year and above those provided by the DSO.

In this Fast Facts, we explore recent data on access to the DSO by students with intellectual disability attending institutions of higher education implementing model demonstration programs called Transition and Postsecondary Programs for Students with Intellectual Disabilities (TPSID). TPSID programs were selected after meeting, reporting, or enhancing high-quality inclusive postsecondary education programs to support positive outcomes for individuals with intellectual disability (e.g., educational attainment, employment, and community inclusion). Annual program and student data for each TPSID were collected by the TPSID National Coordinating Center (NCC) at Think College.

KEY FINDINGS

PROGRAM LEVEL:
In 2015-2016, 58.4% of IHEs reported that students with intellectual disability used the DSO (see Table 1). Programs at 2-year IHEs were more likely to have access to the DSO (93.8% at 2-year IHEs) than students who used the DSO, compared to 55.0% of 4-year IHEs, although this difference was not statistically significant ($\chi^2(1, N=447) = 2.853, p=.092$).

STUDENT LEVEL:
Overall, 63.1% of students attending TPSID programs received accommodations or supports from the DSO (see Table 2). This figure is substantially higher than the percentage of college students with disabilities in general who receive accommodations (24% as reported by Henneman & Mahow, 2015). Students attending TPSID programs at 2-year IHEs were more likely to have access to the DSO (93.8% at 2-year IHEs) than those at 4-year IHEs (55.0% at 4-year IHEs), although this difference was not statistically significant ($\chi^2(1, N=447) = 2.853, p=.092$).

TABLE 1. Percentages of TPSID programs at which students have used the DSO this year

	IHE at which IHE		
	2-year	4-year	Both
Students using DSO	93.8%	55.0%	58.4%
N = 177 programs	23/24	17/30	39/66

TABLE 2. Percentages of students who receive any accommodations or supports from the DSO

	IHE at which IHE		
	2-year	4-year	Both
Students	93.8%	55.0%	63.1%
N = 447 students	23/24	17/30	39/66

Data were collected annually from TPSID on program

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<https://thinkcollege.net/resources/think-college-publications>



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Year 1 TPSID Program & Student Summary Reports

Think College REPORTS

Year One Program Data Summary (2015-2016) from the TPSID Model Demonstration Program

Authors: Clare Papp, Fred A. Smith, & Meg Grigal

SNAPSHOT OF 2015-2016 TPSIDS

449 STUDENTS
59% MALE 41% FEMALE
MEDIAN AGE=20
STUDENT AGES RANGED FROM 16 TO 42
31% OF STUDENTS RECEIVED TRANSITION SERVICES FROM IHE

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Year 2: COMING SOON!



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CHANGING EXPECTATIONS. INCREASING OPPORTUNITIES.

College options for people with intellectual disabilities

- ❖ New look & feel
- ❖ Improved functionality
- ❖ Updated programs database
- ❖ Expanded feature: Innovation Exchange
- ❖ NEW! Families section



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College options for people with intellectual disabilities

FEATURED View all



College Students not Limited by Down Syndrome
Featured on the Born This Way website (A&E), this informative article addresses all the reasons how people with Down syndrome are planning for college, attending college, and enjoying



Job Development -- A Think College Learn module
This module shares strategies for an asset or strength-based marketing approach to job development, focusing on a young person's interests, skills, talents and support needs and



The Path to Higher Education With an Intellectual Disability
This article, recently published in The Atlantic, details the growth of postsecondary programs for students with intellectual disability, featuring ClemsonLIFE and ACE-IT at Virginia



Conducting a College Search: Questions to Ask College Programs
This inaugural How To Think College publication assists families and others in looking for the right college for a youth with intellectual disability. ...Read more

CLICK ON A TOPIC TO FIND:

- Topic Overviews
- Key Resources
- Related Websites
- Ways to Connect
- Frequently Asked Questions

BRAND NEW!!

Paying for College

Vocational Rehabilitation

Employment

For Families

Program Development

Dual Enrollment

<https://thinkcollege.net/resources/innovation-exchange>

CONNECT WITH US!

Ask Us!

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THINK COLLEGE AFFINITY GROUPS

Join Think College Conversations

Connect online with others interested in postsecondary education for students with intellectual disabilities.

Click [HERE](#) To learn more and sign up!

Questions? Contact Rebecca Lazo rebecca.lazo@umb.edu

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MAILING LIST

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ThinkCollege NCC

Update on Vocational Rehabilitation Vocational Rehabilitation 101: Key Principles for Institutes of Higher Education

Russ Thelin, M.S., LVRC, CRC

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Inclusion

Technical Assistance Provider (VR and WIOA),
Think College National Coordinating Center



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Interesting Facts, of Minimal Value

- VR began as the Smith-Hughes Act in 1927, to assist impaired veterans of WW I with wartime based impairment to reintegrated into post-war vocational life.
- In 1920, the Smith-Fess Act created the Citizen Vocational Rehabilitation program, meaning in 2020 VR will be a centenarian, becoming 100 years old.
- The only “Social Services” program that is older than the Vocational Rehabilitation program is the Land Grant College Act.



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Interesting Facts, of Moderate Value



DEPARTMENT of
REHABILITATION

Employment, Independence & Equality

- Over time it was expanded to include;
 - the general citizenry with disabilities,
 - individuals with intellectual/developmental disabilities,
 - individuals with mental health impairments, and
 - Provided presumptive eligibility for SSDI and SSI recipients.
- Eligibility-Based, not Entitlement-Based
- Competitive & Integrated Employment Outcome Focused



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Interesting Facts, of Maximum Value

- Informed Choice
- Individualized Assessment, Counseling and Services
- Categorical Denial Provision
- Due Process Rights and Client Assistance Program (CAP)
- Performance Measures



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Informed Choice (34 CFR 361.52)

- “The vocational rehabilitation services portion of the State Plan must assure that . . . recipients of services . . . are provided . . . informed choice throughout the rehabilitation process.”
- Covers the: employment outcome (career goal), individualized services, service provider, settings in which services will be provided.
- Individualized “interest and informed choice” referenced 28 times in the federal regulations!
- Is not superseded by any other regulatory language



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Individualized Assessment, Counseling and Services

- Services following eligibility are based on individualized needs of each person.
- Individualized needs are determined through both the counseling relationship and other assessment means, as agreed to by the counselor and individual.
- There is no set process that each eligible individual needs to follow as they participate in Vocational Rehabilitation.
- “Comprehensive Assessment of Rehabilitation Needs”



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Categorical Denial Prohibition

- States that VR cannot deny any service categorically: by population or by service.
- Reinforces the individualized nature of services.
- Allows for agencies to have policies as boundaries for services provided, but
- Allows for exceptions to policy on a case-by-case basis as needed.



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Due Process Rights



- Each state must establish a due process pathway for agency/counselor decisions to be appealed.
- Usually found in the agency policy manual, and is a public document.
- The Act establishes and provides funds for each state to have a Client Assistance Program, or CAP, as a source of advocacy for VR clients.



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Common Performance Measures

- WIOA establishes new measures of performance for VR agencies, eliminating long-standing Standards and Indicators
- Abolishes impact assessment from numbers, rates, ratios
- Assesses impact through: job retention, earnings increase, secondary/post-secondary participation, & post-secondary credential attainment (certificate or degree attainment)
- A lot in common, right?



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Last but not least!

From the “Comments” section of the 34 CFR 361:

- “Some commenters recommended that proposed §361.48(b) include other services not already specifically mentioned. Of these commenters, a few **suggested that §361.48(b)(6) allow DSUs to provide tuition and other services for students with intellectual or developmental disabilities in a Comprehensive Transition and Postsecondary Program for Students with Intellectual Disabilities**, as defined by the Higher Education Act of 2008.”
- “Similarly, we clarify here that the vocational and other training services specified in final §361.48(b)(6) **encompass tuition and other services for students with intellectual or developmental disabilities in a Comprehensive Transition and Postsecondary Program for Students with Intellectual Disabilities**, as defined by the Higher Education Act of 2008.”



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Remember . . .

. . . It's not just about the \$\$\$.

. . . The Rehabilitation agency provides counseling, adjustment training, assistive technology, and more.

. . . VR now has a focus on careers and skill development, not just employment.

. . . Synergy, something greater than the sum of both parts, is possible.



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“What we need to do is always lean into the future; when the world changes around you and when it changes against you - what used to be a tail wind is now a head wind - you have to lean into that and figure out what to do because complaining isn't a strategy.”

-Jeff Bezos, Founder and CEO of Amazon



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Stay in the loop about VR



The VR Affinity Group meets quarterly to review and discuss issues, strategies, and results related to the partnership between VR agencies and IHEs.

Register to join at:

<http://www.surveymoz.com/s3/3834983/VR-Affinity-Group-Participant-Survey>



The VR Slack channel is an online community to ask questions, share ideas, and network about issues and ideas related to the partnership between VR and IHEs. Sign up at thinkcollege.slack.com and follow the **#vocational_rehab** channel and message me at **@Russell.Thelin**.

For more information: russell.thelin@umb.edu



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Update on Accreditation Standards and Higher Education Act Reauthorization

Stephanie Smith Lee

Chair, Think College Accreditation Workgroup

Senior Policy Advisor,

National Down Syndrome Congress



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Inclusive Postsecondary Education Progress

- Inclusive postsecondary education (IPSE) for students with intellectual disability (ID) is a growing movement with over 260 programs!
- See www.thinkcollege.net
- Passage of the Higher Education Opportunity of 2008 (HEOA) was key to expansion.
- The HEOA reauthorized the Higher Education Act (HEA), which is now due to be reauthorized again.



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ID Provisions Included in HEOA 2008

- **Federal Student Aid:** Students with ID enrolled in approved Comprehensive Transition Programs (CTPs) now eligible for Pell grants, Federal Supplemental Educational Opportunity Grants and Work-Study jobs (not loans).
- **Model Programs:** Transition and Postsecondary Programs for Students with Intellectual Disability (TPSIDs) enable institutions of higher education (IHEs) to create or expand high-quality inclusive programs for students with ID.
- **National Coordinating Center (NCC):** Think College provides technical assistance, evaluation of TPSID projects, and creates recommended model standards for programs through an Accreditation Workgroup.



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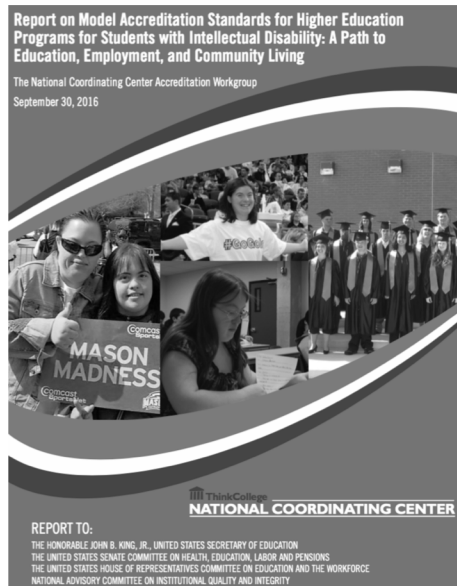
Accreditation Workgroup Update

- HEOA required NCC to establish a group of experts to create model accreditation standards for postsecondary programs for students with ID.
- During first 5 year grant, model standards developed using extensive public input process.
- Report transmitted to Secretary of Education, NACIQI, and Congress



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Report on Model Accreditation Standards for Higher Education Programs for Students with Intellectual Disability

Available as a free download at:
https://thinkcollege.net/sites/default/files/files/resources/AccredReport_WEB_F425.pdf



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New Accreditation Workgroup

Now in Year 3 of new grant, with new workgroup of experts and committees:

- Student Assessment and Learning Outcomes Committee:
 - Developed new draft standard on student learning outcomes
- Accreditation Outreach Committee:
 - Researching options for using standards
- Self-Study Committee:
 - Developed recommendations for field testing standards



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Field Testing Standards

- Survey with model standards.
- Identify at least 8 diverse programs for field testing and invite to participate.
- Determine who will review and review process.
- Training for review sites.
- Sites complete survey and team review.
- Workgroup meets with input from review sites.



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Policy & Advocacy Update: Keep the ID Provisions in the Higher Education Act!

- Inclusive Higher Education Committee (IHEC) led advocacy efforts for changes in HEOA 2008 and appropriations since then. IHEC developed a set of recommendations for Congress to retain and improve ID provisions in the next reauthorization. Co-chair on behalf of NDSC.
- Goal is to ensure ID provisions, with improvements, stay in HEA in the reauthorization.
- If TPSID model demos and National Coordinating Center are not included in reauthorization, the programs will end.

House Democratic Bill

- NDSC strongly supported the *Improving Access to Higher Education Act of 2017*, H.R. 3199, which would add new disability programs to current law, new grants for Universal Design for Learning, and reauthorizes the ID provisions with improvements recommended by IHEC.
- Press conference, action alerts, letters to Congress.

House Republican Bill

- The House Education and Workforce Committee approved on party lines the *Promoting Real Opportunity, Success, and Prosperity through Education Reform Act*” (PROSPER Act), H.R. 4508, to reauthorize the Higher Education Act (HEA) on Dec 12, 2017.
- NDSC is pleased that H.R. 4508 reauthorizes the ID provisions, but we have very serious concerns that other key programs, including disability programs, are eliminated. Read our letter: <https://www.ndsccenter.org/wp-content/uploads/HEA-House-Ltr-12-11-17-FINAL.pdf>
- The House was initially expected to vote on H.R. 4508 this winter. Concerns expressed to House Leadership about bill.

Senate Action on HEA Starting

- Action now focused on the Senate as HEA reauthorization bill(s) are drafted. Not clear yet if there will be a bipartisan bill. Staff still negotiating.
- Senate HELP Committee requested comments on HEA reauthorization.
- IHEC letter signed by many organizations and submitted to the HELP Committee.

100 Organizations Signed Letter to the Senate HELP Committee

- We continued to solicit sign-ons to the letter and 100 local, state, and national organizations signed the letter, which was sent to each member of the Senate HELP Committee. *THANK YOU to all of you who contributed to this success!*
- NDSC met with senior Republican and Democratic HELP staff and senior Education Department officials to review the IHEC recommendations.
- Read the letter at: <https://www.ndsccenter.org/wp-content/uploads/Senate-HELP-Com-ID-letter-3.22.2018.pdf>

Concerns Expressed About IPSE

From public:

- Why would students with ID go to college? Are they just sitting in classes? What do they get?

From Families:

- Some programs not accepting students with ID/significant disabilities
- Demand far exceeds supply
- Lack of residential options
- Cost

From Capitol Hill:

- Outcomes, credentials, “TPSIDs were funded as a pilot and should be finished”, cost

Key Inclusive Higher Education Committee (IHEC) Recommendations

Specific legislative language included in recommendations chart. Key recommendations include:

- Revise the definition of a “Comprehensive Transition Program”:
 - Change “gainful employment” to “competitive integrated employment”
 - Change “curriculum” to “program of study”
 - Require both academic and career development components

Recommendations (cont.)

- Increase inclusive housing opportunities
- Strengthen requirements for meaningful credentials
- Strengthen requirements for outcome data collection
- Address problems with the use of IDEA and vocational rehabilitation funds if the Department of Education does not issue requested guidance

What's Next & What You Can Do

- IHEC letter to the Secretary and an Issue Brief on use of IDEA and VR funds for IPSE is being finalized for sign-ons.
- Organization sign-ons needed. Follow: <https://www.facebook.com/dsadvocates/> for updates.
- Address concerns
- Organized advocacy around IDEA/VR funding issues & reauthorization.

What's Next & What You Can Do

- ***Congressional "Ask": Retain and improve the the ID provisions in the Higher Education Act reauthorization as recommended by the Inclusive Higher Education Committee.*** Share the IHEC letter.
- Let your Members of Congress know this is important to you!
- If one of your Senators is on the HELP Committee, it is especially important you contact them. See list here: <https://www.help.senate.gov/about/members>



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